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WRIT 321 - Personal Essay

Way of the Frog: Amphibious Meditations

Principle #1: The Frog is Unexpected

Furimukeba Kaeru. This is a lyric written by video game director Shigesato Itoi, for a song performed by Akiko Yano in the late 1980s¹. When translated from Japanese to English, it loosely reads: *If you turn around, frog*. This is one of the many principles that a certain small frog has taught me: The South American Horned Frog, known for their circular appearance and comically large mouths². Given their round and chompy disposition, this species of amphibian has earned the nickname of the Pacman frog.

I remember the day you appeared, little one. It was on my phone, in the back room of the cafe, five minutes before my break was over.

Zzzzzz! Zzzzzz!

My phone buzzed on the edge of the desk behind me. I turned around—I snatched it—a text message appeared.

“Hey,” says my girlfriend.

“Promise me you won’t be mad, but...”

A photo pops up on my screen: My girlfriend, our coffee table, and a Pacman frog. On that day, I turned around, and you were there. You appeared when I least expected it.

¹<https://www.discogs.com/release/11430519-Akiko-Yano-Granola>

²<https://www.thesprucepets.com/pacman-frogs-as-pets-1236716#:~:text=As%20strictly%20terrestrial%20amphibians%2C%20they,rounded%20appearance%>

Throughout the flow of time, surprises will appear before us all—surprises we may struggle to deem blessing or curse. You cannot run from them. You cannot hide. They dwell in our timeline, and are coming for us. I sit here now, as ink bleeds into these pages, realizing you taught me this principle, little frog. Rest assured that your appearance was the strangest, most pleasant surprise of all. I want the world to know the wisdom you carried.

Principle #2: The Frog is Present

He always sat in the living room, in the corner nearest to the balcony, where he fashioned a neat little nook for himself—a place to burrow—a place to process—to be alone. I always sat on the opposite side of the room, in a nook of my own design, with my back to him as I worked. Together, we had forged an introvert’s paradise. But his paradise was far more impenetrable than mine, and he would remind me of this frequently. No matter the go-ons of life in this space—be it the neighbor’s party guests banging loudly along the walls, or the panics I’d suffer silently at my desk as I worked—the frog remained still; ever-present in the moment. He would stay peacefully frozen, burrowed in the dirt for days, or even weeks. He lived what was spoken of by Laozi in the *Tao Te Ching*³: “The Master gives himself up to whatever the moment brings.” Truly, my frog was the enlightened one, and I was his pupil.

You taught me this principle of presence, little one. Though you never failed to live and breathe this teaching, I’m afraid I will never be able to match you. You may be enlightened, but you also don’t have to pay taxes. You don’t have to wait in line at the DMV. Frankly, you don’t have to do much at all. You simply just *are*, while my species demands that I must be more. Perhaps we’d all benefit from trying to be a little more like you. In fact, some of us in history have attempted to. Some of them even came close. Consider Alan Watts: A prominent voice of

³ https://ccnmtl.columbia.edu/services/dropoff/china_civ_temp/week03/pdfs/taoteching2.pdf

philosophy in the 1960s—who gained notoriety for teaching eastern philosophical principles to western audiences⁴. In his free time, he lived in a cabin on Mount Tamalpais, California, where he wrote his journals in peace. When he toured the world, he would bring a calm and zen-like aura to each and every lecture. The man truly lived like he walked on air, but if we were to ask him if he had ever achieved frog levels of enlightenment, I think he would laugh, knowing that the goal is impossible. Alan Watts was human, like us:

“I am basically an eternal existence, momentarily and perhaps needlessly terrified by one half of itself.”

- *Alan Watts, 1966, On the Taboo Against Knowing Who You Are*

In essence, my little frog, there are principles of yours that we will never fully embody, despite our best efforts. The most that we can expect are mere glimpses. Despite this, it would be in poor taste to be jealous of you and your relationship with the present moment. No matter the circumstance, you always seemed so still—so at peace. And in doing so, you shared some of that stillness with me. That’s all the enlightening I could ever ask for.

Principle #3: The Frog is a Mirror

The Oxford Dictionary of Philosophy defines *anthropomorphism*⁵ as “the representation of Gods, or nature, or non-human animals, as having human form, or as having human thoughts and intentions.” Philosophers since the late 1500s have described this act as one that clouds our understanding of reality, despite its pervasiveness within our species⁶. According to the *New York*

⁴ <https://alanwatts.org/life-of-alan-watts/>

⁵ <https://www.oxfordreference.com/display/10.1093/oi/authority.20110803095416392>

⁶ <https://www.britannica.com/topic/anthropomorphism>

Times, in 2021, this act exploded in popularity during the COVID-19 pandemic⁷. Humans, young and old, hugged and projected their innermost feelings onto the elusive vessel known as the Squishmallow.

Round, fluffy, and friendly—these purchasable plushies are known to embody the cutest aspects of any given animal—be it cat, dog, hog, or frog. They do not think. They do not feel. They simply exist to absorb our feelings, and perhaps, in a way, mend them. Commonly, humans over a certain age have been shamed underhandedly for interacting with stuffed toys in such a way, but perhaps the isolation from this recent pandemic has flipped the script. It seems we have come to a stronger consensus that these behaviors are socially acceptable. As a Squishmallow enjoyer myself, I for one support this movement. If I am happy, then Claire the Cow is happy. If I am sad, then Harris the Dog is going to be sad with me. But if I were to confess that I engage with my frog in a similar way—to embed my own emotions within its soul—many may tilt their heads in confusion. *They don't think. They don't feel. They're just frogs*, I can hear them saying. *Isn't that behavior toward a frog a little odd?* But in truth, it never felt odd at all—in fact, it felt healing. Given this anthropomorphic renaissance we've found ourselves in, maybe these insecurities are all in my head. Maybe you, reading now, would say the same thing. But for some reason, I feel anxious to admit to anyone that I'd project my neuroses onto my frog.

Nevertheless, little green one, you never judged me for a moment. You agreed to be my mirror, even if you really never felt a thing. Thank you for being there when I needed to reflect.

Principle #4: The Frog is a Timekeeper

Picture a place for me: That one place you know, without a shadow of a doubt, where you feel safe. For many of us, this is a place where we know we can sleep: A bed, a hammock,

⁷ <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/03/16/style/squishmallows.html>

beneath the ceiling, beneath the stars—somewhere we can take time to process the events of our day, and consolidate them into our memory. In video games, *save points* are places that function similarly. Akin to the process of sleep, save points take all of the new experiences of your current play session, and write them into the console's memory. Save points can appear as the player's own bed. Other times, they are bonfires, or a phone call to home⁸. Then, there's the save frog.

Originating from *Mother 3* for the Gameboy Advance, save frogs appear in many forms⁹: The ghost frog, the balloon frog, the fabled car-driving frog—the list goes on and on. They encourage you, the player, to take a seat for a moment's rest. They care deeply about your day, and they want to hear all about it. In this way, they are the timekeepers.

“If you don't take care to preserve your memories, you'll forget them. So, please tell us frogs your memories of everything so far...That is what people refer to as ‘saving.’”

- *Save Frog*

It really is a form of saving, isn't it? And somehow, these frogs always seem to appear right when we need them. But in truth, I have never encountered one of these save frogs. I've never even played *Mother 3*. The save frog I knew sat behind me every day, ready to listen whenever I turned around.

But now, as I write this, when I turn around to look, you aren't there anymore. I wish I could thank you face-to-face for all of the saving you did, but the words on these pages will have to suffice. I find comfort in believing that they will, as writing this allows me to consolidate you

⁸ <https://www.thegamer.com/creative-interesting-save-points-games/#emergency-phones-in-alien-isolation>

⁹ https://mother3.fobby.net/interview/m3int_05.html

into my memory, and the memories of those who happen to read this. I know that won't save you, but it will surely save a part of you. I'll save as many parts as I can—even the slimy ones.

Principle #5: The Frog is Absent

Here, in your honor, old friend, I will conduct an observational experiment.

I will now attempt to be present.

I sit, my chair turned towards your corner. On top of your terrarium, lamplight shines through the holes in the mesh. A sea of fresh dirt pools the floor, while an old leafy house sits at rest in the corner. No one is home. I am sad now. I want to distract myself with my own train of thought. I want to turn tragedy into comedy. I run through an internal dialogue:

Hey, Robs, they'll say.

What's the final personal essay of your writing degree about?

...Dead frogs!?

Wait—I'm distracting myself with my own thoughts. I'm looking for a laugh at a time like this? Why am I doing that? Why can't I allow myself to feel sad? Must there be a joke? Is this disrespectful to the frog? Have I betrayed his honor? If he were to read this, would it make him sad? Goddamn it, I'm anthropomorphising you again, aren't I? I'm not perceiving reality clearly at all. I'm failing to be present.

Maybe I'm failing because I don't want to feel hurt. I'd rather feel happy when I try to remember you, so I use jokes as a way to do that. Perhaps what I truly need to observe are the things that are no longer there, in the corner, grounded in the dirt. It is you. You are the absence. Even when you were living, you were absent; clear-minded; unworried. In knowing that, I also know that you never once pondered the significance of your own death, because you never

could. If that's true, maybe you didn't suffer when your time came. I will never know for sure, but believing it feels right. I realize I'm drifting off into my thoughts once again, leaving this moment in front of me, but maybe that's okay. It seems the very attempt to be present is helping me to accept your absence. Somehow, It feels like you are still teaching me. Perhaps you aren't gone, after all.

Principle #6: The Frog is The Universe

A tree urn is a biodegradable vessel designed to grow a tree infused with one's ashes¹⁰. In this way, it can be considered a form of reincarnation, as the ashes ultimately become one with the tree. Knowing this, the tree will eventually form branches and leaves. It will stand tall, swaying high with the wind, looking down on you. Through this process, it may feel as if a loved one has returned to the earth. In a way, this is true. In another, it is not. We know the *real* them is gone, but we feel that their essence remains. Whenever a branch gains a leaf, a part of that person is born again, and with it, a part of ourselves is healed.

Maybe that's why it felt right to bury you among the trees outside our home. There, you are forever with the dirt. You are in your safe place. You exist there in pieces, decomposed, endlessly becoming one with the earth, as your matter, your energy, and its infinite parts scatter and seep into the roots. You spread through the terrain, lending your energy to the world around you—to beings that dwell underground—to beings that will soon break the earth's surface. By now, you are a plant, a flower, or a tree. By now, you are a bird, and the worm within its beak. Now, whenever I leave home, I look all around me, and know you are there—teaching me that

¹⁰<https://www.thelivingurn.com/pages/tree-zip-code#:~:text=A%20tree%20urn%20is%20a,and%20give%20back%20to%20nature>

none of us are truly gone forever. When my time comes perhaps we'll meet again. Maybe we'll be two trees swaying among each other. That sounds nice.

Though we will never truly grasp the nature of your ways, little friend, you have left me with a glimpse of it through these principles. You showed how life will arrive with unexpected guests. You showed how one can choose to ground themselves, no matter the circumstance. You showed me how you can feel one's presence by exploring their absence. You have shown me how to be a timekeeper, as I attempt to preserve a fraction of your life within these pages. You have shown me how despite our mortality, we will persist forever in other forms. Such is the way of the frog.

Reflection

Considering this essay's themes on reflection, I feel that a reflection on the essay itself is in order. Given this, a few questions remain in my mind. Why did I write all of this in the first place? Why did I attempt to extrapolate philosophical teachings from a small, round amphibian, who never once pondered their own existence? Maybe, by writing this, I was able to give their absence as much meaning as I could. Maybe part of me wrote this in attempts to find meaning in my own mortality. The storm will come for us all in the end, so we must prepare for it gracefully. As a writer who has only experienced a quarter of my lifespan, perhaps this is the best way I know how to right now.

The fact that one can arrive at these thoughts, through writing about something so small, so non-human, as a frog—it's unfathomable. I suppose it is as Itoi once said¹¹: "[Frogs] won't get in your way, yet they do stand out." This process has revealed to me the utility of the personal essay, and creative nonfiction as a genre. By writing in this form, one can observe and reflect on

¹¹ https://mother3.fobby.net/interview/m3int_05.html

the seemingly insignificant, and attribute the findings to ourselves and our environment. Through it, we form a deeper relationship with the world, and we begin to see that this process is therapy. In the end, it is my hope as an author that this form of therapy will be able to reach you, reader. If you ever feel insignificant, or feel at war with the fact that we are temporary, consider consulting your nearest frog. They will be there to listen.

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